The *Indica* is what that lost account by Megasthenes is called; the book has come down to us from fragments and quotations in the works of later classical writers. Doubts about several of these fragments have been raised time and again, it being sometimes unclear whether the writers were paraphrasing Megasthenes direct or using an intermediary.[15] The observations recorded are not always consistent, partly because Megasthenes was prone to speculative grandeur and wanted to say something about *all* of India, both what he knew to be true and what he didn't. He pronounced, for instance, that the women of the 'Pandaian' land bore children when they were 6 years of age, and described a race of men 'among the nomadic Indians who instead of nostrils have merely orifices' and whose legs are contorted like snakes.[16] Yet even those justifiably doubtful of absolute veracity in the account of such a fanciful observer are certain that he had the unprecedented advantage of having seen Pataliputra, and that the fragments in which the description of that city occurs were definitely penned by Megasthenes himself.

Of Indian cities in general he says, 'the number is so great that it cannot be stated with precision'; several, made of brick and mud, stood on 'lofty eminences', while others were built of wood and hugged the banks of rivers or the sea coast.[17] Of these, he only provides an expansive account of 'Palimbothra', the Greek name for Pataliputra, the greatest city in India, in part because of its close connection with the ruling Maurya, for 'the king, in addition to his family name, must adopt the surname of Palibothros, as Sandrakottos, for instance, did.' Whether Chandragupta's name was in fact given suffixed grandeur by his capital city is uncertain, but clearly, even as he built a vast empire, this was the city which formed the core and base of his imperium and of that of the Mauryan monarchs who followed him.

'Sandrakottos' plays second fiddle to Pataliputra in what survives of the Megasthenes account. It was a city that occupied a long strip of land where the Ganga and the Son (called Erranoboas by Megasthenes) met, 'a city